Silhouettes

By Janet O'Neill

SARAH: In my senior English class, I once learned a passage from Alfred Lord Tennyson that started with, "Dreams are true while they last, and do we not live in dreams?" And I always asked myself: *Is the same true for nightmares?*

INTRODUCTION

Recent statistics have shown that one in three teenagers has experienced abuse in a dating relationship. Further statistics show that in the majority of these cases, the victim did nothing to try to stop or prevent the abuse. However, the statistics mean nothing compared to the psychological agony a victim suffers. This agony is brought to light in Silhouettes by Janet O'Neill.

SARAH: Jeff was my third boyfriend. First two were nice enough - one moved away; one found someone with a bigger chest. Jeff was different. He brought flowers. He sent cards. He even went and watched romantic movies with me. I'll even admit the first two months were great. Jeff was the kind of person you'd want to bring home to your parents. At first. I'll never forget my mom

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saying, out loud, in Jeff's presence, *Now, Sarah, I think you've found a keeper this time! Don't screw it up!* My friends adored him: *What's he like? Does he talk?* He seems so quiet. Everyone thought I should stay with him. Everyone but me.

It always started with a slow rage. Boiling inside, his voice a dead calm. He'd see me talk to someone in the cafeteria and say I was a slut. He'd call me a whore. He'd always say *I don't ask for much, just you.* It would start with a slap. Then he'd knock me down. Corner me somewhere. He'd transform into this monster. This being that was there to punish me. He'd kick me 'til I was down. And I would always remember thinking: *Please hit me in the stomach. Don't hit any bones. It hurts so much more in the bones.* He'd go at a faster pace and I could apologize, but it wouldn't stop him. *Please hit me in the stomach. I'll throw up. I want to throw up.*

Now, as they say on the talk shows, there comes a point where the female victim hides the bruises because she's ashamed. I did that for five months. Then one day, I had

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a big bruise on my shoulder and showed it to my mom:

MOM: Oh, what'd you do to yourself now?

SARAH: Mom ... Jeff did this.

MOM: Honey, really. Now wash up for dinner.

SARAH: No mom, please-

MOM: Sarah, you forget that I know how clumsy you are.

SARAH: And he was beating me again. While he hit me in the head, back and forth, he kept saying *I just love you so much.*

One day, I was looking at myself in the mirror. Who is Sarah Murray? A victim or a survivor?

So, I ran away. Far away. Springfield, Oregon. 1,873 miles away. No postcards. No phone calls. Sarah Murray had been reborn. From time to time, I'd wake in sweats, but I could never recall the dream. I started taking classes part time and worked full-time at a pet shop and the sweats became less frequent. I was outgoing. Independent. No one could touch me. I wanted to join something. Socialize. I became active in PETA. That's right, nothing to do with abuse. The new Sarah Murray had never been abused.

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I met a man at the pet shop. His name was Keith. He loved animals as much as I did and seemed to have developed a crush on me. We'd had dinner a couple times, but never a date. Keith knew I wasn't a hugger, a toucher, a close person. Strangely, he liked that about me. I had built a new life. On my own with only $900 to start with. Even had a house. Rental, but a house. Just me. That's all I needed. Then, one night, the phone rang. The phone never rings.

JEFF: Hi, Sarah, it's Jeff Honey, it's Jeff. Are you there?

SARAH: Yes

JEFF: Sarah, I've come for you. I'm in Springfield. I'm getting a job here.

SARAH: How did you find me?

JEFF: Took a while. I knew you needed to be away from your family. It's OK, we're together again.

SARAH: Jeff –

JEFF: I'll stop by tomorrow night. We'll celebrate.

SARAH: And I dropped the phone and started pacing. My hands started to shake and I kept telling myself not to shake. The new Sarah doesn't shake. It wasn't just that he had found me. It was that he would always find me.

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He would find me and the old Sarah would return. Victim Sarah. Please hit me in the stomach Sarah. I kept praying to God: God, I don't want this. God, I don't want this. God, I don't want this. Let me out. Please just let me out of this nightmare.

I went to the garage. Got in the car. Made sure the door was closed and turned the ignition. In an hour, it would be over. Old Sarah would die. New Sarah would live. A final act of defiance. A way of saying Jeff, you can't get me. Fifteen minutes passed. I didn't feel anything. I was calmer, but that was because I was at peace with myself. I would win.

28 minutes. I listen to the radio. Just one more old Beatles song. Play one more. 37 minutes. This is the point I should turn back. This is the point I should come to the realization that it's not so bad. 45 minutes. The music sounds further away. Is a band playing? 51 minutes.

I open my eyes and see a woman next to me. She's a nurse. *You gave us quite a scare,* she says. *Your boyfriend would like to see you.* Jeff enters and holds

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my hand. New Sarah is dead. Sarah the victim is resurrected.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Janet O'Neill
Book: Turning Points
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AWARD HISTORY

2008 National Qualifier
2011 National Qualifier
2019 National Qualifier - MS
IL State Qualifier
KS State Qualifier
MN State Qualifier

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